

Weaving Prosperity: The Role of Textiles in India's Journey to Viksit Bharat

India's textile industry is more than just a link to the past; it's a living, breathing force pushing the country towards a more flourishing and a brighter future. Rooted in tradition but looking firmly ahead, this sector not only keeps Indian craftsmanship alive but also plays a big role in boosting the economy.

Handloom and handicrafts are key segments of the textile industry, keeping India's cultural roots strong while giving the country a competitive edge globally. The handloom sector, with over 4.5 million weavers and workers, is the second-largest source of rural jobs after farming. It produces about 15% of the country's fabric, helping millions of families make ends meet. From the intricate designs of Chanderi to the vibrant colours of Phulkari, Indian artistry shines through. Meanwhile, the handicraft industry supports over 7 million artisans, most of them women, making it essential for economic empowerment and cultural preservation.

Recognising this potential, the government has rolled out several programmes to support and grow these industries. The National Handloom Development Programme (NHDP) is a prime example, helping to improve productivity and quality while ensuring weavers can make a decent living. This programme, along with the Yarn Supply Scheme, provides financial backing to handloom clusters, helping them modernise and tap into new markets. In order to attract private equity and employee more people, the government introduced various schemes such as the Scheme for Integrated Textile Parks (SITP), Technology Upgradation Fund Scheme (TUFS) and Mega Integrated Textile Region and Apparel (MITRA) Park scheme.

India's textile industry is a powerhouse, with a projected market growth from $138 billion to $195 billion by 2025. As the world's largest cotton producer, India is set to produce 7.2 million tonnes of cotton by 2030, fueling a $30 billion market. The Indian Technical Textile sector, with a 10% growth potential, and the composites market, poised to reach $1.9 billion by 2026, reflect India's expanding influence. In FY24, textile exports, including handicrafts, reached $35.9 billion, with the U.S. accounting for 32.7% of this value. The industry employs 4.5 crore workers, sustaining India's legacy in textiles (Source: IBEF).

The market expansion is driven by improved online accessibility and a surge in tourism, which boosts demand for souvenirs and supports local artisans.

Technology is also playing a big role in this success. In places like Varanasi, where the Banarasi saree has been a beloved tradition for generations, artisans are now using digital platforms to reach overseas customers. E-commerce initiatives backed by the government have turned local crafts into international businesses.

State governments are getting into action too. Take Gujarat, for instance—a state with a rich textile history. Its investments in fairs, exhibitions, and trade missions have put its handloom and handicraft products on the global map.

But it's not just the government driving this resurgence. Private companies have seen the value in traditional crafts, not just as cultural treasures but as business opportunities. Brands like Garden Vareli, Fabindia, and Raymond have helped bring Indian textiles to the world stage. Garden Vareli, for example, is known for its high-quality sarees, blending traditional designs with modern flair, and keeping India's textile heritage alive and thriving.

Sustainability is another big focus. With the world increasingly leaning towards eco-friendly products, Indian handloom and handicraft items—famous for their natural dyes and organic materials—are finding new fans globally. This trend not only boosts the appeal of Indian products but also helps protect the environment.

As India works towards becoming a developed nation, its textile industry with its deep roots in both tradition and modernity, shows how ancient wisdom can fuel modern growth. With a mix of government support, private sector innovation, and global appreciation for hand-made goods, this industry is becoming a cultural and economic powerhouse. Each piece of handcrafted work tells an inspiring story of creativity, and the vibrant energy that's shaping a prosperous and diverse future.